

PRACTICAL IMPLEMENTATION KIT

# TAKE YOUR LOCAL SHOP ONLINE

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A step-by-step guide for Indian shopkeepers moving from  
**walk-in customers to online customers**

GUIDE · CHECKLISTS · TEMPLATES  
WORKSHEETS · 30-DAY ACTION PLAN

*For clothing · footwear · handbags · furniture · gifts · home & kitchen · cosmetics · grocery · and other local retail shops*

# How to Use This Guide

This is not a book to read once and forget. It is a working kit. Keep it open next to your phone and laptop while you work through it.

You do not need any technical background. Every part gives you simple steps, ready-to-use templates, and checklists you can tick off.

## What this guide will NOT do

- It will not guarantee a fixed number of sales or a fixed income.
- It will not tell you fake shortcuts like buying fake reviews or followers.
- It will not force you to spend on a website or ads before you are ready.

## What this guide WILL do

- Help you get discovered on Google, WhatsApp, Instagram and marketplaces.
- Give you a simple system to handle enquiries, orders and repeat customers.
- Help you understand your real profit, not just your selling price.
- Give you a 30-day plan so you know exactly what to do, day by day.

*Note: App screens, menus and policies on Google, WhatsApp, Instagram and marketplaces change from time to time. This guide teaches you the principles and the current general steps. Always check the platform's own help section for the latest exact screens.*

## Part 1 — Why Take Your Shop Online?

Today, a customer often decides where to buy before they walk into any shop. They search on Google, check Instagram, or ask on a WhatsApp group. If your shop is not visible there, you have already lost that customer — even if your shop is the best in the market.

### How customers discover businesses today

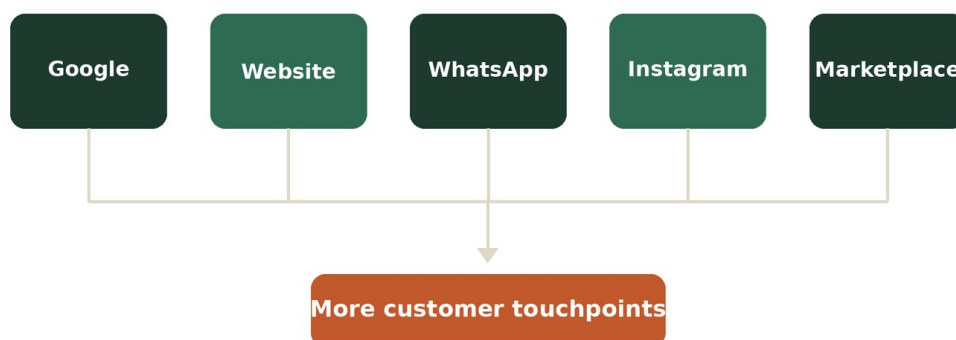
- They search Google ("clothing shop near me", "furniture shop in [area]").
- They see a post or reel on Instagram shared by a friend.
- They get a WhatsApp forward or see your catalogue shared in a group.
- They check ratings and photos before visiting a new shop.
- They compare prices on a marketplace app before buying anything.

### A website alone is not enough

Many shop owners think "I will make a website and customers will come." A website is only one piece. Without Google visibility, WhatsApp follow-up and social proof, a website is like a shop built on a road nobody drives on.

### The five touchpoints that work together

**Google + Website + WhatsApp + Instagram + Marketplace → More customer touchpoints**



| Touchpoint              | What it does best                                            |
|-------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| Google Business Profile | Gets you found by people actively searching nearby           |
| WhatsApp Business       | Converts enquiries into orders through direct conversation   |
| Instagram               | Builds trust and discovery through photos, reels and stories |
| Website / Catalogue     | Gives a professional place to show all products in one link  |
| Marketplace             | Reaches buyers outside your local area who are ready to buy  |

## Common mistakes local shopkeepers make

- Posting product photos with no price, no size and no way to order.
- Replying to enquiries after 1-2 days, by when the customer has bought elsewhere.
- Trying to do everything (website + 3 marketplaces + ads) in week one, then giving up.
- Copying a competitor's page instead of showing their own shop's real strength.
- Never asking happy customers for a review or referral.

*Note: Going online is not a one-time task. It is a small daily habit — reply fast, post regularly, track what works. This guide is built around that habit.*

## Part 2 — Choose Your Online Business Model

Do not try to build a full e-commerce store on day one. Pick the model that fits your product, your time and your budget today. You can move to the next model once the current one is working.

### Model A — Online catalogue

Customers browse your products (on Instagram, Google Photos link, or a simple catalogue website) and contact you directly to buy.

|            | Details                                                    |
|------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| Best for   | Every shop type, especially as a starting point            |
| Cost       | Very low — a phone and free tools are enough               |
| Complexity | Low                                                        |
| Limitation | No online payment or checkout; you close the sale manually |

### Model B — WhatsApp selling

Customer discovers a product (Instagram, Google, referral) and completes the entire order — enquiry, confirmation, payment, delivery details — over WhatsApp.

|            | Details                                                    |
|------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| Best for   | Repeat and local customers who already trust you           |
| Cost       | Free (WhatsApp Business app)                               |
| Complexity | Low to medium — needs discipline in replying and follow-up |
| Limitation | Manual; does not scale well beyond a certain order volume  |

### Model C — Marketplace selling

You list products on platforms such as Meesho, Amazon or Flipkart where they already have buyers searching.

|            | Details                                                              |
|------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Best for   | Standardised products (clothing, footwear, accessories, home items)  |
| Cost       | Free to list; platform takes a commission/fee per sale               |
| Complexity | Medium — needs correct listings, packaging and return handling       |
| Limitation | Lower margin per sale; you don't fully own the customer relationship |

### Model D — Own online store

A dedicated website where customers browse, add to cart and check out, with or without online payment.

|          | Details                                                |
|----------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| Best for | Shops with a steady catalogue and proven online demand |
| Cost     | Low to moderate (hosting, domain, store builder)       |

|            | Details                                                        |
|------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Complexity | Medium to high                                                 |
| Limitation | Needs ongoing traffic — a store with no visitors sells nothing |

## Recommendation for beginners

**Start simple → validate demand → expand gradually.**

1. Start with Model A (catalogue) + Model B (WhatsApp) together — this needs almost no money.
2. Once you get regular enquiries and orders this way, add Model C (one marketplace).
3. Only build Model D (own store) once you have proof that people buy from you online.

## Part 3 — Prepare Your Shop for Online Selling

Before you post a single product online, get these basics right. Fixing them later, after customers start asking questions, costs you more time and trust.

### Preparation checklist by area

#### 1. Product selection

- Choose 10-20 of your best-selling or most photogenic products to start with — not your entire shop at once.

#### 2. Product SKUs (codes)

- Give every product a short code, e.g. SHIRT-BLU-M, so you can track it across WhatsApp, Instagram and marketplaces without confusion.

#### 3. Pricing

- Decide one consistent online price per product. Avoid quoting different prices to different customers — it damages trust and creates confusion.

#### 4. Inventory

- Know exactly how many pieces of each product/size/colour you have before advertising it, to avoid promising what you cannot deliver.

#### 5. Product descriptions

- Write one clear description per product: material, use, care instructions, what makes it special.

#### 6. Measurements / specifications

- For clothing/footwear: size chart. For furniture: dimensions and material. For electronics/appliances: model and specs.

#### 7. Product photography

- Follow the photography checklist in Part 4 before posting anything.

#### 8. Packaging

- Decide how each product type will be packed so it survives transit and looks presentable on arrival.

#### 9. Shipping

- Decide: will you deliver locally yourself, use a local courier, or use a shipping partner? Note approximate cost and time for each.

#### 10. Return policy

- Write one simple return/exchange policy in plain language and use it consistently — do not decide case by case.

#### 11. Customer support

- Decide your working hours for replying to online enquiries and stick to them.

#### 12. Payment methods

- Decide which payment methods you will accept online: UPI, bank transfer, cash on delivery, marketplace-managed payment.

## Printable: Online Shop Preparation Checklist

- ☐ 10-20 starter products shortlisted
- ☐ SKU code created for each product
- ☐ Consistent online price fixed per product
- ☐ Current stock count confirmed for each product/variant
- ☐ One-paragraph description written per product
- ☐ Size/measurement/spec sheet ready
- ☐ Photos taken (see Part 4 checklist)
- ☐ Packaging materials arranged
- ☐ Delivery/shipping method decided
- ☐ Return & exchange policy written down
- ☐ Daily reply-time window decided
- ☐ Payment methods finalised



## Part 4 — Product Photography Using a Smartphone

You do not need a professional camera or a studio. A mid-range smartphone, daylight and a clean background will beat a dark, cluttered photo taken with an expensive camera.

### The basics

#### Lighting

- Shoot near a window in daytime, with soft natural light. Avoid direct harsh sunlight and avoid yellow tube-light at night — it changes the product's true colour.

#### Background

- Use one plain background — a white wall, a plain bedsheet, or a large sheet of chart paper. Remove clutter from the frame.

#### Angles

- Front view, back view, and a 45-degree angle view for most products.

#### Multiple product views

- Show the product from all sides a customer would want to check before buying in-store.

#### Close-up details

- Zoom into stitching, texture, buttons, wood grain, or any special feature that adds value.

#### Size / scale

- Show the product next to a common object (a hand, a chair, a scale) or mention exact measurements in the caption.

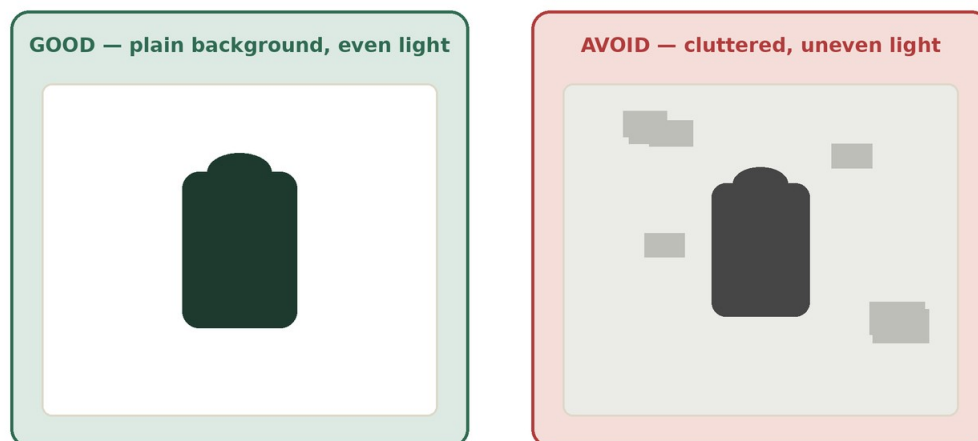
#### Lifestyle photos

- Show the product in use — worn, placed in a room, or being used — so customers can imagine owning it.

#### Before/after examples

- If relevant (e.g. furniture polishing, tailoring), a before/after photo builds strong trust.

## Common photography mistakes



*Illustrative example: a plain, evenly lit background vs. a cluttered one*

- Blurry or shaky photos taken in a hurry.
- Busy backgrounds — shop clutter, other products, wires visible.
- Only one angle shown for the whole product.
- Filters that change the real colour of the product.
- Photos too small or heavily compressed, looking pixelated on a big screen.

## Printable: 10-Photo Checklist for Every Product

- ☐ 1. Front view, plain background
- ☐ 2. Back view
- ☐ 3. Left angle / side view
- ☐ 4. Right angle / side view
- ☐ 5. Close-up of key detail or texture
- ☐ 6. Size/scale reference shot
- ☐ 7. Lifestyle / in-use shot
- ☐ 8. Packaging shot (if packaging is a selling point)
- ☐ 9. Colour/variant group shot (if multiple options exist)
- ☐ 10. One "hero" shot to use as the main listing image

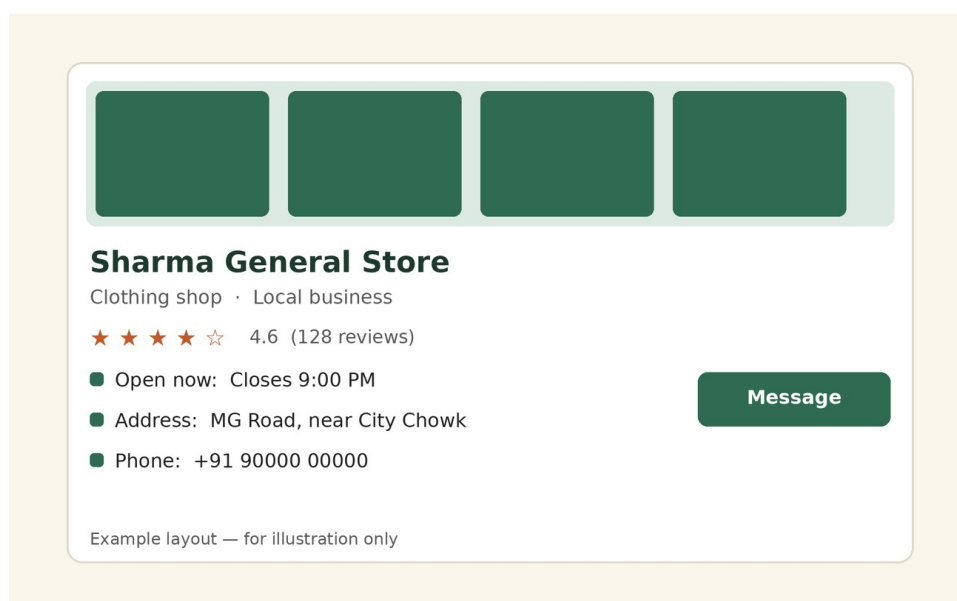
## Part 5 — Create Your Google Business Presence

Most nearby customers searching for a shop like yours will check Google first. A complete, accurate Google Business Profile is one of the highest-value, lowest-cost things you can do.

### What to set up

| Element                  | Why it matters                                                        |
|--------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Business name & category | Helps Google match you to the right searches                          |
| Address & map pin        | Lets customers find your exact location                               |
| Phone number             | Lets customers call directly from search results                      |
| Business hours           | Avoids wasted trips and "are you open?" messages                      |
| Photos                   | Shops with real photos get far more attention than blank listings     |
| Products/services info   | Shows what you sell right on the profile, if the platform supports it |
| Customer reviews         | Builds trust for someone who has never visited your shop              |

### How to ask for genuine reviews



*Illustrative example layout — actual Google Business Profile screens differ*

Ask happy, real customers directly — in person or on WhatsApp after a successful order — to share a short honest review. Never buy reviews or ask for reviews you have not earned.

### A simple ask you can use

*Note: "Thank you for shopping with us! If you were happy with your purchase, a quick Google review would really help our small shop grow. Here is the link: [your review link]"*

### How to respond to reviews professionally

- Thank every positive reviewer briefly and personally.
- For a negative review, stay calm, apologise for the specific issue, and offer a way to fix it (replacement, refund, call).

- Never argue publicly with a customer in the reply — resolve it, then reply politely.

*Note: Do not post fake reviews or misleading business information. Platforms actively remove listings that do this, and it damages long-term trust. Screens and exact steps for setting up a Google Business Profile change from time to time — search "Google Business Profile help" for the current official steps when you set this up.*

## Part 6 — WhatsApp Business for Local Shops

For most Indian local shops, WhatsApp is where enquiries actually turn into sales. Setting it up properly, and replying with ready templates, saves you enormous time.

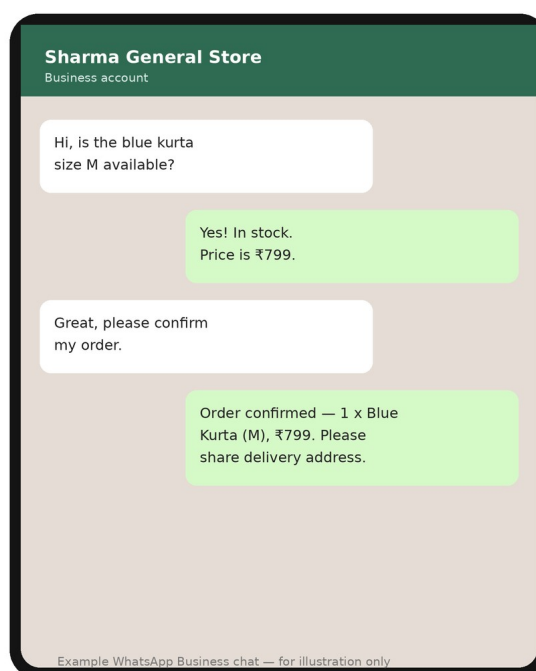
### Set up your profile properly

- Business name, category, address and working hours filled in completely.
- Product catalogue uploaded with photos, prices and short descriptions.
- Profile photo set to your shop logo or a clear shop photo.

### Automation features to use

| Feature          | Use it for                                                         |
|------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Greeting message | First reply to a new customer, even outside working hours          |
| Away message     | Set clear expectations when you are closed                         |
| Quick replies    | Answer common questions (price, size, availability) in one tap     |
| Labels           | Tag chats as New enquiry / Order confirmed / Paid / Shipped / Done |

### Ready-to-use message templates



*Illustrative example conversation — actual WhatsApp screens differ*

Copy, adjust the [ ] placeholders, and save these as Quick Replies in WhatsApp Business.

#### 1. New enquiry

*Note: Hi! Thank you for your interest in [product name]. It is available in [sizes/colours]. Would you like me to share more photos or the price?*

## 2. Product availability

Note: Yes, [product name] is currently in stock in [size/colour]. Would you like to place an order?

## 3. Price enquiry

Note: The price of [product name] is ₹[amount], inclusive of [details]. Delivery charges are ₹[amount] or free above ₹ [amount].

## 4. Order confirmation

Note: Your order for [product name] x [qty] is confirmed. Total amount: ₹[amount]. Please share your delivery address and preferred payment method.

## 5. Payment confirmation

Note: Thank you! We have received your payment of ₹[amount]. Your order will be packed and shipped within [X] days.

## 6. Shipping update

Note: Your order has been shipped via [courier name]. Tracking ID: [ID]. Expected delivery: [date].

## 7. Delivery confirmation

Note: Hi! We hope your order reached you safely. Please let us know if everything is as expected.

## 8. Follow-up

Note: Hope you are enjoying your [product name]! Do let us know if you need anything else.

## 9. Review request

Note: We would love to hear your feedback! If you have a moment, a short Google review would mean a lot to our small shop: [link]

## 10. Repeat customer offer

Note: As a valued customer, here is [X]% off on your next order this month. Just message us to redeem.

## Part 7 — Instagram for Local Businesses

Instagram works best as a discovery channel — people find your shop through a reel, story or post, then message you or check your Google listing.

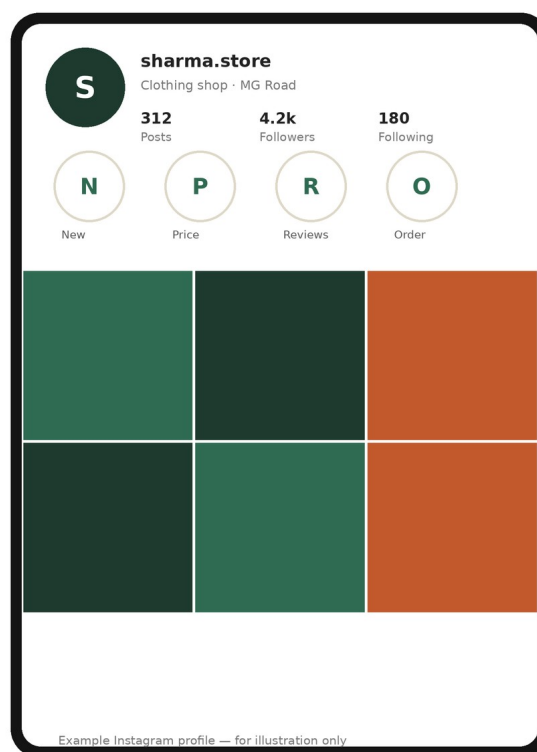
### Profile setup

- Switch to a Business/Creator account for insights and a WhatsApp/contact button.
- Write a clear bio: what you sell, your location, and how to order (link or WhatsApp).
- Use a clear logo or shop photo as profile picture.
- Set up Highlights for categories: New Arrivals, Price List, Reviews, How to Order.

### Posting consistency and local discovery

- Post consistently rather than in bursts — 3-4 posts a week is more effective than 10 posts one week and none the next.
- Tag your city/area and use local hashtags so nearby customers can discover you.
- Share customer photos and messages (with permission) as social proof.

*Note: Posting alone does not guarantee sales. Consistent, honest posting builds visibility and trust over time, which then supports sales through WhatsApp, your website or marketplaces.*



*Illustrative example profile — actual Instagram screens differ*

### 20 content ideas

1. New arrival showcase
2. Best-seller of the week
3. Behind-the-scenes at the shop
4. Customer testimonial/review screenshot

5. Price list carousel
6. How-to-order explainer
7. Styling/usage tips
8. Size guide post
9. Festival/seasonal collection
10. Limited stock alert
11. Comparison of two products
12. Packaging/unboxing
13. Shop tour
14. Meet the owner
15. Customer photo repost
16. FAQ answered
17. Combo/bundle offer
18. New colour/variant launch
19. Care instructions post
20. Milestone post (e.g. 100 happy customers)

## 10 reel ideas

1. Quick shop tour
2. Product close-up with trending audio
3. Before/after transformation
4. Styling a product in 15 seconds
5. Unboxing a new arrival
6. Day in the life of the shop
7. 3 ways to use/style this product
8. Customer reaction/testimonial
9. Restocking shelves
10. Packing an order for delivery

## 10 story ideas

1. Poll: which colour should we stock next?
2. Behind-the-scenes packing
3. Countdown to a sale
4. New arrival sneak peek
5. Repost a happy customer's story
6. This or that (product comparison)
7. Q&A sticker for customer questions
8. Today's offer
9. Quick tip related to your products
10. Swipe-up/link to catalogue



## Sample captions

*Note: "New in store: [product name] in [colour]. Available now, sizes [X-Y]. DM or WhatsApp us at [number] to order."*

*Note: "Loved by our customers — here's what [customer name] had to say about their [product name]. Thank you for trusting us!"*

## Simple 30-day posting calendar

| Week   | Mon                      | Wed                   | Fri                 | Sun               |
|--------|--------------------------|-----------------------|---------------------|-------------------|
| Week 1 | New arrival post         | Styling tip           | Customer review     | Behind the scenes |
| Week 2 | Best-seller reel         | FAQ post              | Offer/combo post    | Shop tour story   |
| Week 3 | Size guide post          | Customer photo repost | Limited stock alert | Poll story        |
| Week 4 | Milestone/thank you post | New variant launch    | Testimonial reel    | Monthly recap     |

## Part 8 — Build a Simple Website

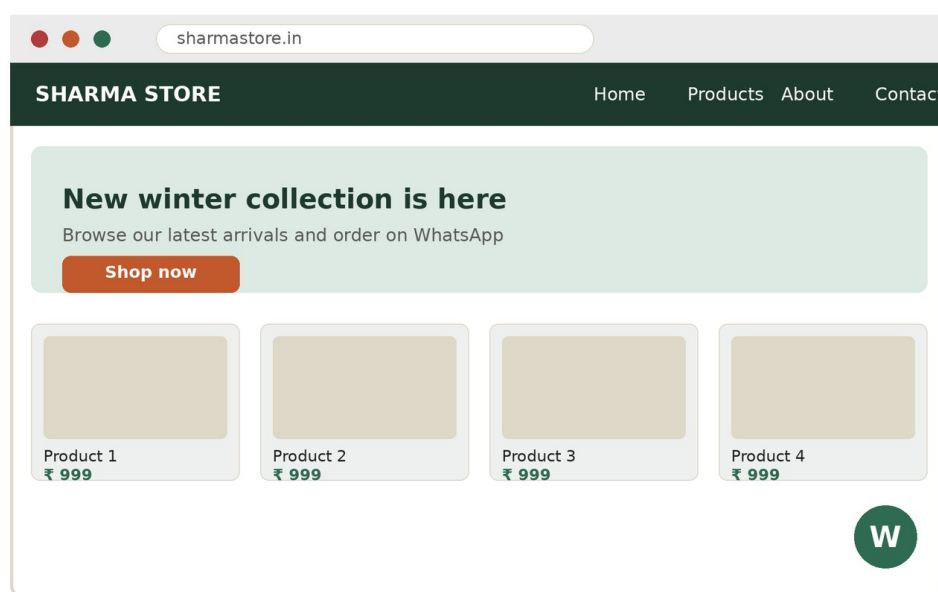
A website is not always the first thing you need — but as your online presence grows, it becomes a professional home for your shop that you fully control.

### Three levels — choose what fits you now

| Level                 | What it does                                                | Best when                                                      |
|-----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Catalogue website     | Shows products with photos and prices; no ordering built in | You are still validating demand                                |
| Enquiry website       | Products + an enquiry/contact form or WhatsApp button       | You get steady enquiries and want a professional link to share |
| Full e-commerce store | Customers add to cart, check out and pay online             | You have proven, repeated online demand                        |

*Note: Do not jump straight to a full e-commerce store because it "looks professional." A store with no visitors and no proven demand is wasted money. Move up a level only when the level below is already working.*

### What a basic local-shop website should contain



*Illustrative wireframe — for layout reference only*

- ☐ Home page with a clear headline and what you sell
- ☐ About page with your shop's story and location
- ☐ Products page with categories
- ☐ Individual product detail pages (photos, price, description, size)
- ☐ Contact page with phone, address and map
- ☐ WhatsApp button visible on every page
- ☐ Location/map embed
- ☐ Business hours
- ☐ Reviews/testimonials section

- ☐ FAQ section
- ☐ Return/shipping information page (if applicable)

## Part 9 — Marketplace Selling

Marketplaces such as Meesho, Amazon and Flipkart already have millions of buyers searching daily. Selling there means tapping into that existing traffic — but it comes with fees, rules and competition.

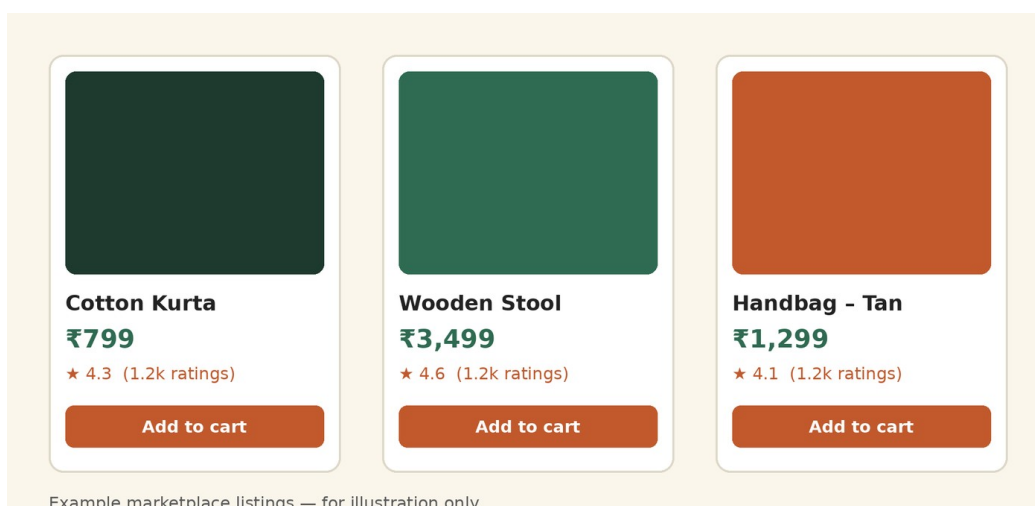
### When marketplaces make sense

- Your product is fairly standardised (size, colour, spec can be listed clearly).
- You can maintain consistent stock and quality across orders.
- You are comfortable with the marketplace's fees eating into your margin.

### The general process

1. Product selection — choose items that photograph and ship well.
2. Seller registration — sign up as a seller with your business/GST details as required by the platform.
3. Product listings — enter titles, descriptions, images, price and stock for each item.
4. Titles & descriptions — clear, keyword-rich, and honest about what is included.
5. Images — follow the photography checklist in Part 4; most marketplaces have specific image requirements.
6. Pricing — factor in marketplace fees before setting your price (see Part 10).
7. Shipping — decide whether you self-ship or use the marketplace's fulfilment service, where available.
8. Returns — understand the platform's return window and who bears the cost.
9. Customer ratings — deliver consistently to protect your seller rating.
10. Order management — track every order status until delivery and payment settlement.
11. Profit calculation — recheck actual profit per order after fees and returns.

### Platforms to consider



Example marketplace listings — for illustration only

Illustrative example listings — for layout reference only

| Platform | General fit                                                                          |
|----------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Meesho   | Low-cost entry, popular for clothing, accessories, home items, reseller-driven model |
| Amazon   | Wide reach, more structured seller requirements, strong for                          |

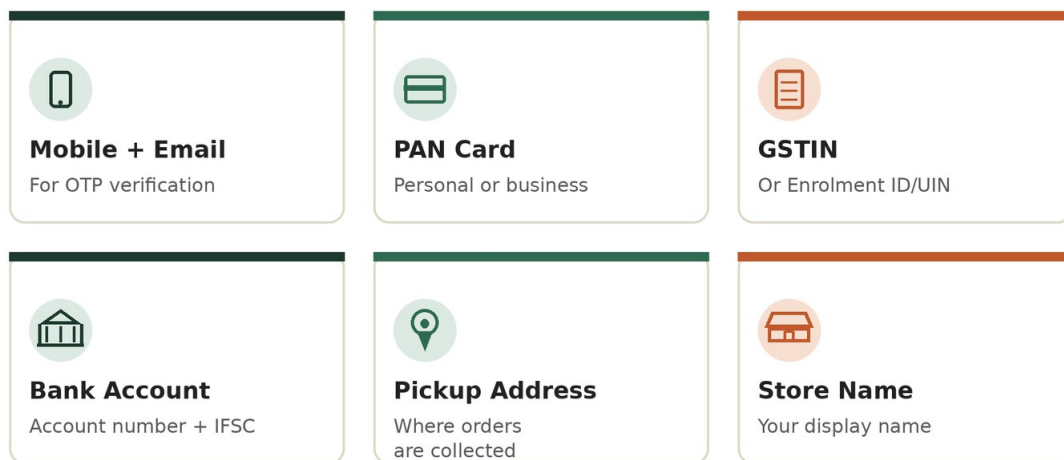
| Platform | General fit                                                                  |
|----------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|          | branded/standard products                                                    |
| Flipkart | Strong India-wide reach across many categories, structured seller onboarding |

*Note: Fees, eligibility, category rules and registration steps differ by platform and change over time. Do not treat any specific number in this guide as fixed — always confirm current fees and policies on the platform's own official seller help pages before listing.*

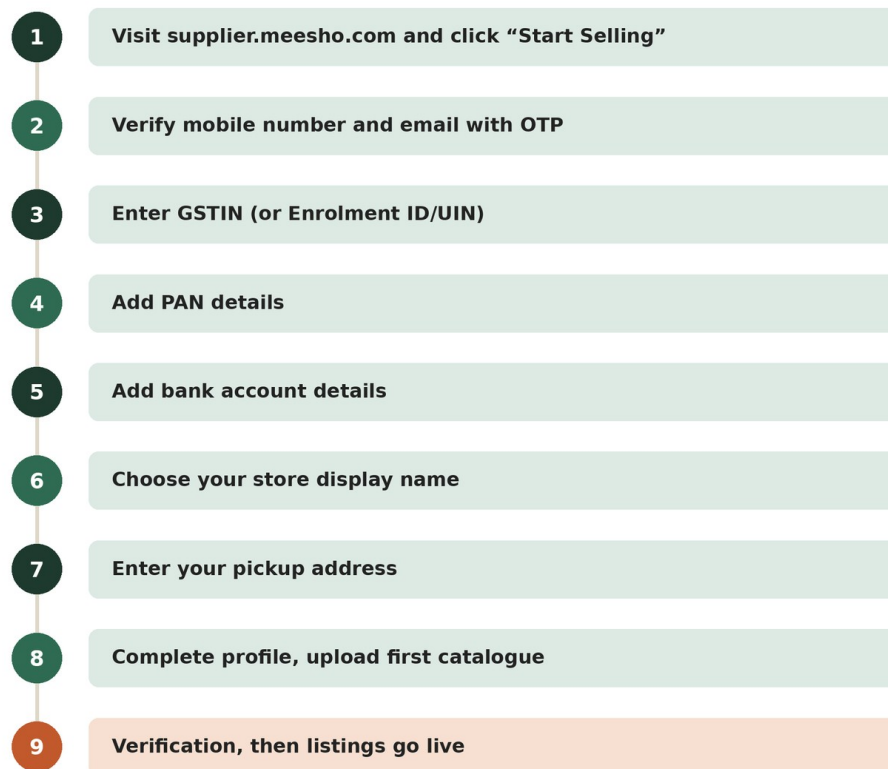
## How to register on Meesho — step by step

Meesho is usually the easiest marketplace for a first-time seller to start on, so here is the direct registration process. These are the current general steps — exact screens can change, so treat this as a checklist to follow on [supplier.meesho.com](https://supplier.meesho.com) rather than a fixed script.

### What you need before you start



## Registration steps



*Note: Registration itself is free. Commission, payment cycle (orders are typically settled a fixed number of days after delivery) and category-specific rules can change, so confirm the current numbers on the Meesho Supplier Panel itself before you rely on them for pricing.*

## Part 10 — Pricing & Profit

This is one of the most important parts of this guide. Many shopkeepers look only at selling price and feel they are doing well — until they calculate real profit and find it is much lower, or even negative.

### Selling price is not profit

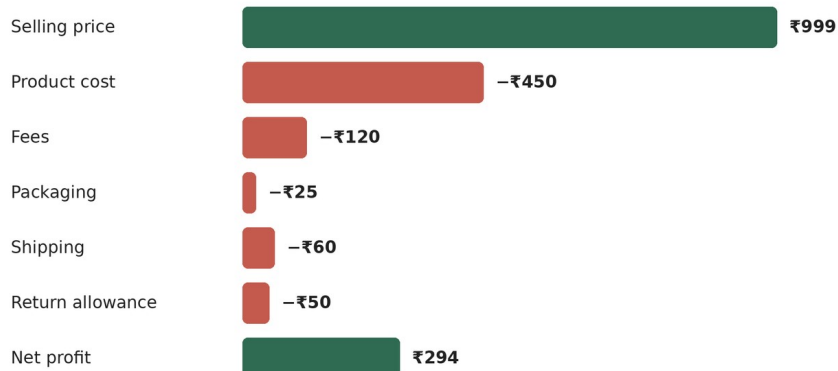
**Selling Price** is what the customer pays. **Profit** is what remains after every real cost is subtracted.

#### The formula

*Note: Selling Price – Product Cost – Marketplace/Payment Fees – Packaging – Shipping/Other Costs – Return/Damage Allowance = Net Profit*

### Worked example (illustrative numbers only)

| Item                                               | Amount (₹) |
|----------------------------------------------------|------------|
| Selling price                                      | 999        |
| Product cost                                       | – 450      |
| Marketplace/payment fee (illustrative 12%)         | – 120      |
| Packaging                                          | – 25       |
| Shipping                                           | – 60       |
| Return/damage allowance (illustrative 5% of price) | – 50       |
| Net profit                                         | = 294      |



*The same breakdown shown visually*

*Note: These numbers are illustrative examples only, to show how the calculation works. Your actual product cost, platform fees and shipping cost will be different — always use your own real numbers.*

### More worked examples across shop types (illustrative numbers only)

The same formula applies to every category — only the numbers change. Here are two more examples so you can see the pattern before filling in your own worksheet.

#### Example: clothing/footwear shop, a kurta priced at ₹799

| Item          | Amount (₹) |
|---------------|------------|
| Selling price | 799        |

| Item                                                                                | Amount (₹) |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| Product cost                                                                        | - 340      |
| Marketplace/payment fee (illustrative 15%)                                          | - 120      |
| Packaging                                                                           | - 15       |
| Shipping                                                                            | - 50       |
| Return/damage allowance (illustrative 8% — higher for clothing due to size returns) | - 64       |
| Net profit                                                                          | = 210      |

### Example: furniture shop, a wooden stool priced at ₹3,499

| Item                                                                     | Amount (₹) |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| Selling price                                                            | 3,499      |
| Product cost                                                             | - 1,800    |
| Marketplace/payment fee (illustrative 8% — lower category fee)           | - 280      |
| Packaging (crating for a bulky item)                                     | - 150      |
| Shipping (bulky/freight)                                                 | - 400      |
| Return/damage allowance (illustrative 3% — furniture returns less often) | - 105      |
| Net profit                                                               | = 764      |

*Note: Notice how furniture carries a higher rupee cost per item but a lower percentage return rate, while clothing has a lower per-item cost but a higher return rate. Always calculate your own category's real numbers instead of assuming one formula fits everything equally.*

### Profit Calculator Worksheet (fill in manually)

| Product | Selling Price | Product Cost | Fees | Packaging | Shipping | Return Allowance | Net Profit |
|---------|---------------|--------------|------|-----------|----------|------------------|------------|
|         |               |              |      |           |          |                  |            |
|         |               |              |      |           |          |                  |            |
|         |               |              |      |           |          |                  |            |
|         |               |              |      |           |          |                  |            |



## Part 11 — Getting Your First 10 Online Customers

You do not need a big advertising budget to get your first customers. You already have a network — this part shows you how to use it ethically.

### Where your first 10 customers usually come from

1. Existing shop customers — tell every walk-in customer you are now online too.
2. Your WhatsApp contacts — send a warm, non-spammy message with your new catalogue.
3. Family and referral network — ask people you trust to share your catalogue link.
4. Your Google Business presence — respond quickly to anyone who finds you there.
5. Instagram — engage with local pages/communities, not just your own followers.
6. Local community groups — share relevant, useful posts, not just "buy now" messages.
7. Your existing customer database — old bills/contacts are a ready-made customer list.
8. Repeat customers — a satisfied customer is often your easiest next sale.
9. Local partnerships — cross-promote with a nearby, non-competing shop.
10. Marketplace discovery — new buyers who find you purely through search on the platform.

### What not to do

- Do not spam unrelated WhatsApp groups with your catalogue.
- Do not buy fake reviews or fake followers.
- Do not advertise "discounts" that are not real (fake original price, then "70% off").
- Do not make misleading claims about materials, origin or quality.

## Part 12 — Order Management System

Without a system, online orders quickly become confusing — messages get lost, payments go untracked, and customers stop trusting you. A simple tracker fixes this.

### The order workflow

*Note: Enquiry → Product confirmation → Order → Payment → Packing → Shipping → Delivery → Feedback → Repeat purchase*



### Order-Tracking Template

| Customer | Product | Qty | Price | Payment Status | Shipping Status | Delivery Status | Return Status | Profit |
|----------|---------|-----|-------|----------------|-----------------|-----------------|---------------|--------|
|          |         |     |       |                |                 |                 |               |        |
|          |         |     |       |                |                 |                 |               |        |
|          |         |     |       |                |                 |                 |               |        |

Keep this in a simple spreadsheet (Google Sheets or Excel works fine) or a notebook — the tool matters far less than the habit of updating it after every order.

## Part 13 — 30-Day Action Plan

Every day has one or two concrete tasks. Do not skip ahead — each week builds on the previous one.

### Week 1 — Prepare the business and products

| Day | Task                                                                         |
|-----|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1   | Shortlist 10-20 starter products; create an SKU code for each one            |
| 2   | Fix one consistent online price for every product on your list               |
| 3   | Write a short description for each product (material, use, care)             |
| 4   | Note exact measurements/specifications for each product                      |
| 5   | Take photos for your first 5 products using the 10-photo checklist           |
| 6   | Take photos for the remaining products; decide packaging and shipping method |
| 7   | Write your return/exchange policy; complete the Part 3 Preparation Checklist |

### Week 2 — Set up Google, WhatsApp and Instagram

| Day | Task                                                                         |
|-----|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 8   | Set up or complete your Google Business Profile (details, hours, photos)     |
| 9   | Set up your WhatsApp Business profile (name, category, hours, address)       |
| 10  | Upload your product catalogue into WhatsApp Business                         |
| 11  | Save all 10 WhatsApp message templates from Part 6 as Quick Replies          |
| 12  | Set up/optimize your Instagram business profile, bio and contact button      |
| 13  | Create Instagram Highlights: New Arrivals, Price List, Reviews, How to Order |
| 14  | Post your first 2 pieces of content and ask 3-5 happy customers for a review |

### Week 3 — Create catalogue/website and marketplace presence

| Day | Task                                                                                  |
|-----|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 15  | Decide your website level (catalogue / enquiry / full store) from Part 8              |
| 16  | Build or finalise your chosen catalogue/website, or your Instagram+WhatsApp catalogue |
| 17  | Decide which marketplace(s), if any, fit your products (Part 9)                       |
| 18  | Complete marketplace seller registration                                              |
| 19  | List your first 5-10 products on the marketplace with full details and photos         |
| 20  | Fill in the Profit Calculator Worksheet for every product you have listed anywhere    |
| 21  | Review pricing and correct anything showing low or negative profit                    |

## Week 4 — Start customer acquisition, track and improve

| Day | Task                                                                          |
|-----|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 22  | Message existing WhatsApp contacts about your new online catalogue            |
| 23  | Ask family and your referral network to share your catalogue link             |
| 24  | Post on Instagram; reply to every DM and comment the same day                 |
| 25  | Engage with 2-3 local community pages/groups with genuine, useful posts       |
| 26  | Set up the Order-Tracking Template and log every order from this point on     |
| 27  | Follow up with anyone who enquired but hasn't ordered yet                     |
| 28  | Send a repeat-customer offer to your first buyers                             |
| 29  | Run through the Online Business Audit Checklist (Part 14) honestly            |
| 30  | Score yourself on the Business Readiness Score and plan month 2's focus areas |

## Part 14 — Templates & Resources

A quick reference of every template in this guide, gathered in one place.

### Product listing template

| Field                       | Your entry |
|-----------------------------|------------|
| Product name                |            |
| SKU code                    |            |
| Category                    |            |
| Price                       |            |
| Size/colour/variant options |            |
| Stock count                 |            |
| Description                 |            |

### Product description template

*Note: [Product name] — made from [material]. Available in [sizes/colours]. Ideal for [use case]. Care instructions: [details]. Price: ₹[amount].*

### Customer information sheet

| Field             | Your entry |
|-------------------|------------|
| Name              |            |
| Phone/WhatsApp    |            |
| Address           |            |
| First order date  |            |
| Products bought   |            |
| Notes/preferences |            |

### Expense tracker

| Date | Item | Category | Amount (₹) |
|------|------|----------|------------|
|      |      |          |            |
|      |      |          |            |
|      |      |          |            |

### Online Business Audit Checklist (use monthly)

- ☐ Google Business Profile is complete and up to date
- ☐ WhatsApp catalogue reflects current stock and prices
- ☐ Instagram has been posted to consistently this month
- ☐ Every enquiry from this month was replied to within your target time

- ☐ Order tracker is fully updated with no missing entries
- ☐ Profit calculator reviewed — no product selling at a loss unnoticed
- ☐ At least 3 new reviews collected this month
- ☐ One repeat-customer offer sent out this month

*Note: The Product Photography Checklist, all 10 WhatsApp Message Templates, the Online Shop Preparation Checklist, the Profit Calculator Worksheet, the Order-Tracking Template, the Content Calendar and Content Idea lists are in Parts 3, 4, 6, 7, 10 and 12 above — kept there so each is next to the explanation of how to use it.*

## Part 15 — When to Scale

Excitement is not a reason to scale. Numbers and customer demand are.

### Signs you may be ready to scale

- You are consistently running out of stock on your bestsellers.
- Your reply time is slipping because order volume is genuinely too high to manage manually.
- Your profit calculator shows healthy, consistent margin — not just high sales volume.
- Customers are asking for products or variants you don't currently offer.
- You have 2-3 months of stable data, not just one good week.

### Ways to scale, in rough order of complexity

1. Add more products within categories that are already working.
2. Add another marketplace once the first one is running smoothly.
3. Consider small, targeted paid advertising once you know your profit margin per product.
4. Upgrade from a catalogue website to an enquiry site or full e-commerce store.
5. Invest in dedicated packaging that reflects your brand.
6. Hire help for packing, photography, or customer replies.
7. Use inventory software once manual tracking becomes error-prone.
8. Use a CRM/customer tracker once your customer list outgrows a spreadsheet.
9. Automate repetitive replies and follow-ups once volume justifies it.
10. Build a proper e-commerce operation with dedicated staff and systems.

*Note: Don't scale because you're excited. Scale when the numbers and customer demand justify it.*

# Shop-Type Playbook

The core system in this guide (Google + WhatsApp + Instagram + catalogue/store + marketplace) works for every kind of local shop. But each category has its own priorities. Use this playbook to know what to focus on first for your specific shop.

## Clothing shops

| Area                 | What to focus on                                                                      |
|----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Best starting model  | Catalogue + WhatsApp selling; add a marketplace once sizing/returns are under control |
| Photography priority | Fit on a body/mannequin, fabric close-up, and a clear size chart photo                |
| Biggest risk         | Size-related returns — a clear, honest size chart reduces this significantly          |
| Marketplace fit      | Strong — clothing is one of the most searched categories on Meesho, Amazon, Flipkart  |

## Footwear shops

| Area                 | What to focus on                                                     |
|----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Best starting model  | Catalogue + WhatsApp, expanding to marketplace for standard sizes    |
| Photography priority | Sole detail, side profile, and true colour under natural light       |
| Biggest risk         | Sizing mismatches — always mention the size standard used (UK/US/EU) |
| Marketplace fit      | Strong for standard branded/semi-branded footwear                    |

## Handbag / accessories shops

| Area                 | What to focus on                                                                      |
|----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Best starting model  | Instagram-led discovery + WhatsApp closing, since these are visually driven purchases |
| Photography priority | Lifestyle shots (bag being carried/worn) plus material and hardware close-ups         |
| Biggest risk         | Customers doubting material quality without touching it — close-up photos help        |
| Marketplace fit      | Good, especially for everyday-use and gifting categories                              |

## Furniture shops

| Area                 | What to focus on                                                                         |
|----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Best starting model  | Catalogue website with enquiry form; WhatsApp for final negotiation and delivery details |
| Photography priority | Full piece in a styled room setting, plus dimensions clearly stated in every listing     |
| Biggest risk         | Shipping cost and damage in transit — factor this fully into your profit calculation     |



| Area            | What to focus on                                                                                      |
|-----------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Marketplace fit | Selective — works best for smaller, easier-to-ship pieces; large furniture often stays local-delivery |

## Gift shops

| Area                 | What to focus on                                                                      |
|----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Best starting model  | Instagram + WhatsApp, timed around festivals and occasions                            |
| Photography priority | Packaging and presentation — gifting is often an emotional, presentation-led purchase |
| Biggest risk         | Missing festival/occasion timing — plan content 2-3 weeks before key dates            |
| Marketplace fit      | Good for standardised gift items; personalised/custom gifts do better via WhatsApp    |

## Home & kitchen product shops

| Area                 | What to focus on                                                                                   |
|----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Best starting model  | Catalogue + marketplace, since these are often repeat, comparison-shopped purchases                |
| Photography priority | Product-in-use shots (in an actual kitchen/home setting) plus size/capacity details                |
| Biggest risk         | Customers comparing you purely on price against larger sellers — highlight quality/service instead |
| Marketplace fit      | Strong — one of the most active categories across all major marketplaces                           |

## Cosmetic shops

| Area                 | What to focus on                                                                                |
|----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Best starting model  | Instagram-led (reels/tutorials) + WhatsApp for ordering                                         |
| Photography priority | True-colour shade shots, ingredient/label close-ups, and before/after where honest and relevant |
| Biggest risk         | Trust and authenticity concerns — clearly show batch/expiry and sourcing where relevant         |
| Marketplace fit      | Good, but check each platform's specific category requirements for cosmetics before listing     |

## Grocery / general stores

| Area                 | What to focus on                                                                           |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Best starting model  | WhatsApp ordering for a local delivery radius; Google Business for local search visibility |
| Photography priority | Less critical than other categories — focus instead on an accurate, up-to-date price list  |
| Biggest risk         | Stock/price changing daily — keep your WhatsApp catalogue and price list                   |

| Area            | What to focus on                                                                       |
|-----------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                 | current                                                                                |
| Marketplace fit | Limited for a single local shop; local delivery via WhatsApp is usually more practical |

## Small manufacturers and other local retailers

If your shop doesn't fit neatly into one category above, apply the same test to decide your priorities: is your product visually driven (lean on Instagram + photography) or trust/spec driven (lean on clear descriptions, measurements and Google reviews)? Most shops are a mix of both — use whichever leans stronger for your specific products.

# Frequently Asked Questions

## **I have very little time every day. Where should I start?**

Start with just two things: a complete Google Business Profile and a working WhatsApp Business catalogue. These take the least ongoing effort and already make you discoverable and contactable. Add Instagram and marketplaces once these two are running smoothly.

## **Do I need to spend money to get started?**

No. Google Business Profile, WhatsApp Business and Instagram are all free. Marketplaces charge a fee only when you actually sell. A website is the only step in this guide that may involve a small ongoing cost, and it is optional until you have proven demand.

## **What if I don't get any orders in the first few weeks?**

This is common and does not mean the system has failed. Recheck: Are your photos clear? Is your price visible and clear? Are you replying within your stated time window? Are you actually telling existing customers you are online? Most early silence comes from one of these gaps, not from the overall approach.

## **Should I offer cash on delivery?**

It can increase orders from first-time online buyers who are still building trust with you, but it also carries a higher risk of refused deliveries. Many shops start with prepaid-only or a partial advance payment, and add cash on delivery later once they have a track record.

## **How do I handle a customer who wants a refund?**

Refer to the return policy you wrote in Part 3 and apply it consistently to every customer. Respond calmly, confirm the issue, and process the return/refund per your stated policy rather than deciding case by case.

## **Can I use the same photos and prices across WhatsApp, Instagram, my website and marketplaces?**

Yes, and you should — consistency across platforms builds trust. Just make sure you update all of them together whenever a price or stock level changes.

## **How do I know if I am ready to add a second marketplace or start paid ads?**

Refer to Part 15 (When to Scale). The short answer: only once your current channels are running consistently, your profit calculation is healthy, and demand is outgrowing what you can currently handle.

## Glossary of Terms

| Term                    | Meaning                                                                                                          |
|-------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| SKU                     | A short unique code you give each product/variant to track it easily across platforms                            |
| Catalogue               | An organised list of your products with photos, prices and details, shared digitally                             |
| Google Business Profile | Your free business listing that appears on Google Search and Maps                                                |
| Marketplace             | A platform (such as Meesho, Amazon, Flipkart) where many sellers list products for buyers to browse and purchase |
| Net profit              | What you actually keep after subtracting all real costs from the selling price                                   |
| Quick reply             | A saved, reusable WhatsApp Business message you can send with one tap                                            |
| Highlight               | A saved collection of Instagram Stories that stays visible on your profile                                       |
| Reel                    | A short vertical video format on Instagram, often used for discovery                                             |
| Enquiry                 | An initial customer message asking about a product, before an order is confirmed                                 |
| Cash on delivery (COD)  | A payment method where the customer pays at the time of delivery, not in advance                                 |
| Return window           | The number of days a customer has to request a return or exchange after delivery                                 |
| Seller rating           | A score marketplaces assign to sellers based on order fulfilment and customer satisfaction                       |

## Business Readiness Score

Score your shop honestly from 0 to 2 on each area below (0 = not started, 1 = partially done, 2 = fully done).

| Area                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | Score (0-2) |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|
| Product readiness                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |             |
| Pricing                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |             |
| Photography                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |             |
| Inventory                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |             |
| Google presence                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |             |
| WhatsApp                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |             |
| Instagram                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |             |
| Website                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |             |
| Marketplace                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |             |
| Packaging                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |             |
| Delivery                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |             |
| Customer support                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |             |
| Profit tracking                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |             |
| <b>What your total score means</b><br><br>0–8 → Not ready. Focus on Parts 1-3 first.<br><br>9–16 → Getting ready. Focus on completing your weakest areas.<br><br>17–24 → Ready to launch. Follow the 30-Day Action Plan with confidence. |             |



*Note: This is a practical self-assessment framework created for this guide — not an industry-standard metric. Use it to track your own progress over time.*

## A Final Word

Taking a shop online is not one big leap — it is a series of small, consistent steps. Most shopkeepers who succeed online are not the ones with the biggest budget. They are the ones who reply fastest, post consistently, and treat every online customer with the same care as someone walking into their shop.

You now have the guide, the checklists, the templates and the 30-day plan. The next step is simply to begin with Day 1.

*If at any point you would rather have this entire setup — Google Business Profile, WhatsApp Business, Instagram, catalogue/website and your first marketplace listings — done for you instead of doing it yourself, that is exactly the kind of hands-on shop setup support this guide's author offers separately.*